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The Wonderland model of toxic creativity in leadership: When the "never again" impossible becomes not only possible but actual

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Abstract

We suggest that toxic creative leaders succeed by creating a fantastic future in a fantasy world that we call "Wonderland." They make what was thought to be impossible, not only possible but actual. The game is similar to board games that bring one of the players playing them to some wonderful destination at the end of the game. The future they create, however, is an illusion, designed to appeal to people who feel under-appreciated, disempowered, victimized, deprived of material or other resources, or in need of a radical change that will empower them. The creatively toxic leaders are usually underestimated and their overwhelming skills at acquiring and maintaining power are viewed as malleable for other powerful people's purposes. Ultimately, the toxic creative leaders take over and end up manipulating rather than being manipulated by those who had sought to use the leaders for their own ends. We discuss some of the ways that can be used to combat toxic creative leaders so that what should have been "never again" stays that way—in the realm of impossibility.

Keywords

Autocrats, creativity, dark creativity, dark intelligence, dictatorship, impossibility, possibility, toxic leaders, Wonderland

"Never again." This well-known phrase, associated with the main lesson learned from the Holocaust, is so widespread that it even has its own Wikipedia page (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Never_again). The phrase has over 7.4 billion hits on Google and is one that each of us learned even from early childhood. After the Holocaust, it seemed impossible that the kind of genocide and dictatorial power invested in one person—an absolute dictator of questionable intent—ever would stain the countries of the world again. Yes, it seemed *impossible*. But

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today, countries are not only electing dictators (Dictatorship Countries, 2024; Kaylan, 2014), but the dictators seem to be winning because no one knows quite what to do about them (Applebaum, 2021). Psychology, as a field, has been almost oblivious, with a very small number of notable exceptions (Gilbert, 1950; Moghaddam, 2013, 2019). Most of the theorizing about dictatorship has come from political science and journalism (e.g., Albright, 2018; Applebaum, 2021; Geddes et al., 2018; Paxton, 2005; Snyder, 2022) and in one case, from neuroscience (Haycock, 2019).

Milgram (1974/2009) confronted experimentally the elements of people's psychological makeup that lean them toward authoritarianism, but his work could never be repeated today as it was done, for ethical reasons. Milgram, in a variety of studies, had participants enter an experimental setting, accompanied by an accomplice (who was a professional actor) of the experimenter. They were to enter an experiment on the effects of punishment on learning. Each of the two participants drew lots to determine which would be a "teacher" and which would be a "learner." Unbeknownst to the participants, the lots were rigged so that the accomplice was always assigned to the role of "learner" and the real participant to the role of "teacher." (Both lots said "teacher," but the real participant did not know that and thought he or she uniquely was being assigned to the role of teacher.). The participant was then asked to administer shocks administered by a supposed shocking machine to the learner every time the learner made a mistake in learning a list of words. The learner was unaware that the shocks were fake. As they went through the experiment, the shocks supposedly became more painful until they became "extreme" and possibly "fatal."

The main question was what proportion of participants would go to the top of the level of the shock apparatus in administering shocks. Although participants (teachers) could leave the experiment any time, when they asked to do so, the experimenter did all he could to verbally persuade the participants to stay in the experiment, including telling them that they could not leave (when, of course, they could leave merely by getting up and walking out). To the horror of the field and the world, the fraction that went to the top of the supposed shock scale was roughly two-thirds, although the exact fraction varied depending upon circumstances, such as whether the "teacher" could see the "learner" or not. Milgram thereby learned that, even in an experiment in a laboratory, people were surprisingly obedient.

Milgram's work, in turn, derived in part from a rich body of work in psychology on the authoritarian personality, dating back to Adorno et al. (1950). Authoritarians are people who have extremely high respect for persons in authority and who are very likely to be obedient to those persons in authority, as well as to the institutions they represent. These individuals also tend to show hostility toward minorities and outgroups in general. They are more likely to hold stereotypes and prejudices against people who are perceived as not belonging to their preferred group. Authoritarian, toxically creative leaders gain power either through force or, these days, through elections, often falsified or won on the basis of false pretensions of their ability to create or re-create a wonderful land (which we refer to as "Wonderland" in this article) that the leaders assure their followers they deserve but have been deprived of. The authoritarians may be either right-wing or left-wing, but in the end, their techniques are pretty much the same; they offer a supposed Wonderland to their followers, based on the notion that Wonderland has been stolen from them by a real, or often, imagined opposition.

Milgram's study, of course, was grounded in the past. But it was very much oriented toward a future possibility—that the authoritarian leadership structures of the past were not just remnants of the past but might be impending threats for the future as well. As Faulkner (1950/2012) warned us in his famous work,

Requiem for a Nun, "The past is never dead. It's not even past." What seems past often merely lies in wait as a possibility and, at times, a probability for the future. Like a chronic cancer, *1984*-like authoritarianism may go into remission, but it does not disappear.

Altemeyer (1981) studied right-wing authoritarianism and sought to go beyond the heavy psychoanalytic orientation of the earlier work by Adorno and colleagues. Altemeyer found that people with right-wing authoritarian leanings show high levels of submission to authorities whom they perceived to be legitimate. They are generally aggressive, and they perceive this aggression as sanctioned by those authorities whose power they accept. They show a high level of conformity and adherence to social conventions endorsed by society (i.e. those in society whom they perceive to be like them). They also tend to be closed-minded (Kruglanski, 2013). Altemeyer further found that right-wing authoritarianism is anything but rare; rather, it is pervasive in society. In the United States (Inglehart & Norris, 2017) and worldwide, right-wing authoritarianism is on the rise (J. T. Jost et al., 2003, 2008; J. Jost & Hunyady, 2018), and it is not limited to the right-wing. As Altemeyer pointed out, left-wing authoritarians often want to overthrow the existing government: The difference between the people with authoritarian leanings toward the left versus toward the right is more one of situational context and circumstances than it is of underlying personality. Authoritarian followers of any persuasion tend to be rigid, uncreative, and to project onto others the weaknesses that exist within themselves (Montuori, 2005, 2019).

It is important to distinguish between authoritarian leaders and authoritarian followers. The followers tend to be rigid and less creative than many others. The leaders, however, to gain power, or to last in power, must be quite creative, if darkly so (Maisel, 2017; Sternberg, 2010a, 2010b). They may call upon a fixed playbook, but every situation requires a different implementation of that playbook. They need creatively to adjust the playbook to their own circumstances—the grievances of their constituents, the alleged dangers of their time and place, and the mechanisms of repression and punishment that are likely to work in their particular situation. If the authoritarian leaders are not sufficiently darkly creative, as well as darkly intelligent, they lend themselves to being overthrown or harmed. They also need to adopt creative measures to protect themselves from both expected and unexpected threats. As we write, one authoritarian leader, Robert Fico, was shot five times the day before (Kottasová et al., 2024). Authoritarian leaders can never let down their guard.

Right-wing authoritarianism certainly did not end with World War II. As Santayana (1905/1998) recognized, before any of the events leading up to World War II, "Those who cannot remember the past are condemned to repeat it." The world right now is experiencing what would have seemed impossible less than a century ago: a resurgence not only of dictatorships but of elected dictatorships. What was thought to be impossible—never to happen again—is happening. It is not just the dictators. The world has witnessed a resurgence of genocides, certainly in Ukraine (Atlantic Council, 2023) and likely in a number of other countries as well (Relief Web, 2024).

The dictatorships of today show some similarities to those of the past. But they are also creative, exploiting the psychology of perceived victimhood in creative ways that are, at least historically, relatively new. They show how what was thought to be impossible has become not only possible, but intertwined with the actual (Possibility Studies Network, 2024).

Creativity involves the generation of ideas or innovations that are novel and useful (Kaufman & Sternberg, 2019). Creativity is largely a social construction (Glaveanu et al., 2020). That is, what is viewed as creative is also contextual: It depends on the idea or product, where it is created, when it is created, and for whom it is created.

In this essay, we will be discussing creativity primarily in the context of governmental power.

Many of the ideas discussed in the essay, however, apply to other contexts as well. In the essay, a number of terms will be used for forms of government, and it would be useful to define them from the start. Our definitions below are based on *dictionary.com*, but similar definitions can be found elsewhere (e.g. https://www.cia.gov/the-world-factbook/field/government-type/):

We define a *democracy* as "government by the people; a form of government in which the supreme power is vested in the people and exercised directly by them or by their elected agents under a free electoral system" (https://www.dictionary.com/browse/democracy). It is a system of majority rule. We define an *autocracy* as a government in which one individual has complete, uncontrolled, and potentially unlimited authority over all others. A *dictatorship* is a form of autocracy (usually one that is repressive); a *monarchy* (potentially) is another form of autocracy if the monarch has absolute power. An *anocracy* is a mixture or hybrid of democracy and autocracy, sometimes referring to a government that is moving from one of those forms to the other. Creativity, of individuals in society or of those who govern or seek to govern society, is generally seen as sociocultural good, regardless of context. But sometimes creativity takes a dark turn, especially when its purveyors are malignantly narcissistic and even tyrannical individuals, especially, purveyors who are leaders (Mehraein et al., 2023; Sternberg, 2019a, 2019b). In such cases, creativity is not serving as a sociocultural good, but as a good exclusively for the creator and the creator s cronies.

The Nature of Creative Toxicity

Creative leadership is generally good for organizations and society, whether in kitchens (Bouty & Gomez, 2013; Feuls et al., 2021), management and organizational leadership (Hughes et al., 2018; Mainemelis et al., 2015; McFeely, 1968; Mumford et al., 2002, 2019; Zaccaro et al., 2015), or in the world more generally (Gheerawo et al., 2020; Mumford et al., 2000; Puccio et al., 2011). But unfortunately, creative leadership also has a dark side. In this essay, we mainly focus on toxic creative leaders at a national level, even though they can exist in more everyday settings, too. The same principles apply at all levels—only the mode of implementation differs.

Tyrannical leaders are typically exemplars of what has come to be called "dark creativity," or creativity that often, but not always, is constructed to serve detrimental, harmful, or in the extreme, even toxic purposes (e.g. Cropley et al., 2008, 2010; Cropley & Cropley, 2019; Gutworth et al., 2018; Hao et al., 2016; Harris et al., 2013; James et al., 1999; James & Taylor, 2010; Kapoor & Kaufman, 2022a, 2022b, 2022c; Sternberg, 2010a, 2010b; Wiltermuth et al., 2017). Sometimes, leaders who are toxic lead their followers to become toxic as well (Goldhagen, 1997).

Creatively toxic leaders are not merely toxic. That is, they do not merely harm, imprison, and kill people. Rather, they find novel and effective ways of successfully gaining and keeping power, confounding their rivals, who often are more experienced politicians. The creatively toxic leader breaks the rules that most politicians follow and thereby confuses and disempowers their rivals. In today's world, a leader who is toxic but not creative is at risk of being quickly deposed because toxic leaders engender a great deal of opposition, and the opposition seeks to overthrow them in ever-new and sometimes effective ways. For example, a number of business leaders who were toxic but could not figure out how to stifle their opposition have, in recent times, ended up being deposed by that opposition (The Economic Times, 2018). They learned that it is one thing to gain power and be toxic; it is another to figure out creative ways to stay in power when the opposition to one's toxicity starts to build (Sternberg, 2018).

Not all creativity that is dark is intentional. The makers of the drug Vioxx created the drug to relieve pain and inflammation, not knowing when the drug was created that it might later be

linked to cardiovascular problems (Prakash & Valentine, 2007). One may create a harmful idea or product thinking that the idea or product will be neutral in its effects, or even positive.

Unfortunately, products not invented to become dark can become dark. That is, their long-term negative effects may not have shown up in the short term. For example, Philips Respironics created and sold a CPAP (continuous positive airway pressure) machine to facilitate breathing as an invention that would help those who had breathing issues. But when they discovered that its use could have malignant side effects, apparently, as too often happens, they continued selling the product anyway (Cenziper et al., 2023). As we write, there is a massive class-action lawsuit against the company.

When dark creativity is enacted purposefully and maliciously, it is often called *malevolent creativity*. And when it is extremely harmful, as in causing loss of lives and livelihoods, it is referred to here as *toxic creativity*. The Sackler family's essentially uncontrolled pushing of opioids, even after the tremendous harm they were causing had become clear, would squarely fall into the category of toxic creativity, as defined here (U.S. Department of Justice, 2020). Viktor Orban, another creatively toxic leader, has systematically undermined democratic principles in Hungary (Beauchamp, 2018; European Parliament, 2022).

The Protocols that Creatively Toxic Leaders Follow

Creatively toxic people, and especially, leaders, can do a great deal of harm to a lot of people. Leaders who are malevolently creative, as one might expect, are also more likely to show dark-triad personality traits (Jia et al., 2020). Creative people and especially leaders, toxic or not, sometimes tend to have personality traits that put them into the dark-triad spectrum (Lebuda et al., 2021). Toxic leaders, according to Lipman-Blumen (2006) and others (Sternberg, 2019a, 2019b):

1. Feed their followers' illusions, no matter how outrageous the illusions are;
2. Impair their followers' abilities to act independently so that the followers essentially become tools of the toxic leaders;
3. Manipulate followers' deepest needs and fears in order to make the followers pliable to the leaders' manipulations;
4. Deceive and deliberately misdiagnose problems to their own advantage;
5. Undermine institutions, norms, rules, and processes, so that the institutions become recognizable in "name only";
6. Build totalitarian regimes where they are the sole leading source of power;
7. Set constituents against one another so that no strong unified opposition can take root;
8. Train followers to scapegoat, shun, or hate those who do not follow the leader;
9. Mistreat the weakest and bestow more power on the powerful, in a bizarre application of the Matthew principle, whereby the strong become stronger (and usually, richer) and the weak become weaker (and usually, poorer);
10. Utilize scarce resources for personal gain, as they are in it for themselves;
11. Ignore the plight of their followers in the aftermath of crises, as the followers are no longer of use to them;
12. Disregard or support incompetence, cronyism, and corruption, which become hallmarks of most such regimes;
13. Act with incompetence that injures their followers and the organizations for which they are responsible, as their sense of responsibility extends only to their own self-interest.
14. Want more power, but they don't admit to it. They pretend to care about their people, whereas in reality, they just think about their own benefits.

15. Realize that they often can benefit from the misery of other people, including ones for whom they are supposed to be responsible. For example, leaders may sacrifice their own citizens to increase the death toll and toll of the wounded so that they can appeal for international sympathy and aid. Their followers become pawns in a sick game, whereby the more the followers are harmed, the more international and sometimes internal support for the leaders increases.
16. Ally with other toxic leaders because their interests are aligned. Thus, countries such as present-day Russia, China, Iran, North Korea, Venezuela, and Belarus, form alliances because they realize that all democracies, especially ones close by geographically, are a threat to them. Would-be dictators express their admiration for autocratic leaders (Cillizza & Williams, 2019; Coleburn, 2016) because they are wannabe autocrats. Kellerman (2004) has pointed out that bad and, indeed, toxic leaders can be bad in different ways. They may be (a) incompetent; (b) rigid; (c) intemperate; (d) callous; (e) corrupt; (f) insular; (g) evil. The word "evil" has such moralistic and even Biblical undertones that some people are reluctant to apply it, but in our view, like Kellerman's, that is a serious mistake. By giving evil leaders various benefits of the doubt, hoping that no one really is "all bad," we can end up with leaders committing genocide, as has happened recently within China against Uyghurs living in China and by Russia against Ukrainians living in Ukraine (Ibrahim, 2023).

Toxic creative leadership can take a variety of forms. Often, it takes the form of a dictatorship, although it may be called anything—a "democracy," a "republic," a "democratic republic," a "socialist republic," and so forth. Most dictatorships are toxic because power is so corrupting, and even governments that start off or appear to start off as benevolent dictatorships often do not stay that way (Klaas, 2023; Stockman, 2023). Some people believe that dictatorships run effective governments, but that is largely a myth, in part due to the effective propaganda of the dictators.

In 2022, one-quarter of the countries of the world, covering half of the land area of the globe, were ruled by dictators (Riggio, 2022). Given that creatively toxic people and especially leaders are, well, toxic, one might wonder why anyone would interact with, or even follow them. Psychologists have suggested a number of different reasons. How do such leaders amass large, and sometimes, even majority followings? Riggio (2019, 2022), Dreher (2020), and Rock (2016) have suggested some answers, for example, based in part on Lipman-Blumen's (2006) work:

1. People like strong leaders and confuse arrogance and narcissism with strength.
2. People are credulous (see also Sternberg, in press) and fail adequately to question what the leaders claim.
3. People are reluctant to engage in critical thinking–because they do not wish to be bothered, because they are afraid of what the result will be, because they are habitually lazy in their thinking habits, or because they never learned how to think critically (see also Velez & Power, 2020, 2023).
4. People accept their in-group's perspectives and statements of alleged facts unquestioningly.
5. People believe that the alternative to the toxic leader is worse.
6. People rationalize away the leader's faults and mistakes.
7. People see the leader be what they believe to be effective in some domain and tell themselves that, for whatever their flaws, the leader is effective.

8. People bask in power by association.
9. Some people share in the power or resources accumulated by the toxic leader.
10. Many people care primarily about their own socioeconomic wellbeing. Beyond that, they let other people deal with the problems their society may face.
11. People often lack courage. They might like to do something, but do not have the courage to do it (see Rate et al., 2007; Rate & Sternberg, 2007; Sternberg, 2022).
12. People want simple solutions to complex problems.
13. People want to externalize their problems—blame others for what has gone wrong.
14. People believe the leader when he says the people should be fearful because they are under attack and that only he (it usually, although not always, is a "he") can save them.
15. People are attracted to the leaders' certainty and the idea that all problems can be solved by one person if only he gets their support.
16. People may be fearful for what will happen to them and their loved ones if they do not join with others who are joining.
17. People's demands are usually arrayed on a slippery slope. People are asked to believe and act on increasingly immoral demands.
18. People sometimes become part of a mob. Personal responsibility is cast aside as they enjoy the benefits of anonymity.
19. People convince themselves that if everyone else is following the leader, the others must know what they are doing, so they should follow the leader too.
20. People are convinced by the charisma and charm of the toxic leader.

Toxic creative leaders have an enormous advantage that people often are unwilling or unable to see. The advantage is that most people do not see how enormously talented these individuals are. They are blinded because the people have narrow folk conceptions of creativity and intelligence (Sternberg, 1985) or are relying on conventional psychometric conceptions of intelligence (Carroll, 1993; Deary, 2020; Sackett et al., 2020), such as general intelligence or IQ, and creativity (Kaufman & Sternberg, 2019; Runco & Jaeger, 2012). Because these leaders do not look like conventional exemplars of high abilities (Sternberg, Preiss & Karami, 2023; Sternberg, Tromp & Karami, 2023)—they are not, in any way, like Einstein, Pasteur, Picasso, Kahlo, Renoir, Shakespeare, Goethe, Mandela, Gandhi—people often see them as of quite limited abilities. Yet, these toxic creative leaders have the abilities to take over entire countries, religious cults, lines of business, or whatever. They have an ability to gain and, often, to exercise, absolute control that is exceptionally rare and almost always underappreciated until it is too late. Because they are underestimated, they take control and then turn on many of the people who either opposed them or thought that they would just come and go—some of those in the opposition may disappear into the night.

Today's toxic leaders almost have to be creative to be successfully toxic. They invariably have a lot of enemies, including not only leaders who are nontoxic, but also competing toxic leaders. As the situation around them changes, they need to update their strategies and tactics, sometimes hiding their authoritarianism, as Vladimir Putin did in the earlier years of his presidency of Russia, and other times, trumpeting it, as Putin has done more recently. They have to figure out to engineer their election and re-election so that the votes seem at least minimally credible, have to combat attempts to overthrow them, have to try to either keep people happy or keep them from interfering, have to be aware of allies who may secretly be enemies, have to keep up with changing technologies, and the like. Being a toxic leader today

without creativity is a recipe for a very short term of leadership.

Is creativity—and high levels of diverse abilities, including, more generally, applied intelligence (Sternberg et al., 2008)—more important to the sustainability of toxic leadership than in the past? We believe these abilities are indeed more important. First, many toxic leaders and their toxic successors used to be installed by wars, coups, and insurrections. Might made "right." It still can, but not as easily as in the past. Today, most toxic leaders are "elected," but in most cases, the elections are shams or the result of biased electoral procedures (such as in the United States, where the archaic system of a so-called "electoral college" tends to tilt elections to empower rural voters at the expense of urban ones—Badger, 2016). China and the Soviet Union both got their first so-called "Communist" leaders through battle. Today, both autocratic countries, like most other autocratic countries, hold sham elections where many diverse means are employed to give the impression that an election, other than in name, actually was held. Venezuela recently held an outrageously sham election in which Nicolás Maduro lost in a landslide but simply and untruthfully claimed victory on the basis of obviously falsified results. Meanwhile, greatly enhanced communications make it possible for enemies at great distances to influence public opinion. Russia enforces obedience through a global program of assassinations (Klain, 2020) that sends the message that dissenters can be reached and silenced anywhere. China uses a system of a global police force, establishing "police stations" in countries around the world to enforce obedience to the Chinese dictatorial system of government (Dos Santos, 2022). And the insurrection of January 6, 2021, in the United States, sent the message that some leaders of at least one political party were willing to resort to creative means to establish the government of their choice, not of the entire electorate's choice. These means could not have existed in the past. They make darkly creative use of technology to enforce autocratic and often merciless levels of control.

The advantage that darkly intelligent and creative leaders have is that they are not people who are likely to be recognized as extremely intelligent or creative. The result is that people underestimate them and when they take over, their takeover is attributed to almost anything besides the masterful use of the leaders' intelligence and creativity for dark purposes.

What are the abilities that successful creative toxic leaders have that go unnoticed? First, these leaders are darkly creative. They think of unusual ways to cause harm. Second, they are darkly intelligent (Sternberg, 2023). Dark intelligence has little or nothing to do with the knowledge and abstract-analytical abilities that constitute intelligence as conventionally defined. It is something quite different.

Dark intelligence is adaptive behavior that is detrimental, harmful, malign, or even toxic. Unfortunately, though, it is adaptive for the darkly intelligent and, typically, few others. Dark intelligence shows a problem with individualistic notions of intelligence as the ability to adapt to the environment ("Intelligence and Its Measurement," 1921). What is adaptive for one person—the person who deploys their dark intelligence—may be maladaptive, harmful, and even fatal for others. For example, the aspiring dictator may gain by using darkly intelligent strategies; the people he will rule, lose. The same, of course, applies to dark creativity.

Dark intelligence typically involves dark creativity and dark creativity involves dark intelligence, but they are not the same. Dark creativity is more generative and productive, dark intelligence more analytical and rigorous in working out the possible implications of a move, as in chess (Sternberg, 2024). The production and utilization of killer drones would be an example of the combination of toxic creativity and toxic intelligence (Hernandez, 2021). This production is just one example of how artificial intelligence can be used in ways that are not only destructive to particular groups,

but that also might ultimately be destructive to all of humanity (Roose, 2023; Vincent, 2023). Other examples of dark creativity and dark intelligence are the destruction of what was left of democracy in Russia (Mozur et al., 2022) and similar attempts that are prevalent in the United States by some members of political parties (Levitsky & Ziblatt, 2018, 2023; Mounk, 2018; Roosevelt et al., 2023; Sternberg, in press; Sternberg & Fischer, 2023). Social media today are being used on a continual basis for toxic purposes, often with the true purpose hidden by the appearance of benevolence (Schöne et al., 2021).

The Role of the Dark Triad

People who are darkly creative and darkly intelligent tend to be narcissistic, Machiavellian, and often, psychopathic—the so-called "dark triad" (Paulhus & Williams, 2002). However, having a dark triad personality does not make one darkly intelligent or darkly creative. The darkly intelligent and creative have the cognitive and other skills to turn their destructive personality into effective action that is harmful to those around them. One can have the personality traits but, without the dark creativity and dark intelligence, be ineffective in applying them to one's goals in the everyday world.

Darkly intelligent and darkly creative people presumably exist in all populations throughout time. But broader contextual factors in societies can act as a "springboard" for potential dictators or other types of autocrats to rise to power (Moghaddam, 2013). Situational factors combined through historical accident and intentional design create opportunities for the darkly intelligent and darkly creative to gain power. Adolf Hitler, for example, rose to power in the context of the German defeat in World War I. Many Germans felt humiliated by the terms of the Treaty of Versailles, which many deemed unfair and which placed a disproportionate burden on the country (Bessel, 1993). This broader historical context, coupled with engineered blame for the burning of the Reichstag after Hitler was elected as German Chancellor (Evans, 2005), resulted from dark intelligence and dark creativity, and demonstrated the ability of potential autocrats to use these skills as a springboard to dictatorship.

We like to think of people as too smart to fall for toxic leaders, but research has shown that smart people can think and act in ways that are extremely foolish (Sternberg, 2002a). They often think they are too smart to act foolishly, which is precisely what sets them up to act in a foolish way (Butler, 2017; Stanovich, 2009; Stanovich et al., 2013; Stanovich, 2021; Stanovich & West, 2000; Sternberg, 2002b). Stanovich, in particular, in his research program, has shown that high-IQ people are prone to breakdowns in rational thinking, even though one might think they would not be, given their IQs. Sternberg has argued that high-IQ people overgeneralize the value of their high IQs, so they are not on guard to counteract the foolishness to which anyone is susceptible. Tversky and Kahneman (1981) (see Gilovich et al., 2002) have done extensive work showing that very intelligent people are highly susceptible to biases in their thinking of which they are largely or totally unaware.

Board Games Seeking a Wonderful Goal

Board games provide children, and often adults, with an opportunity to have fun and, sometimes, to strategize. But what if they inadvertently teach at least some children to think in ways that lead to unrealistic expectations or frames of mind for the future? What if they, ironically, set up a mindset in which players come to believe that following a series of prescribed steps, including those proposed by a would-be dictator, will lead them to the kind of "Wonderland" that one reaches at the end of some of these games? We first describe the games and then the possible consequences of the mindset they may induce.

There are a number of enjoyable board games for children that are educational as well

as fun. The children learn many skills from playing these games, such as (a) following directions, (b) realizing that the directions are the same from one game to the next and one player to another, (c) taking turns, (d) having patience, (e) being a good winner, (f) being a good loser, (g) recognizing that sometimes both good things and bad things can happen with no particular identifiable reason, (h) that games have endings, (i) that in games of pure luck, one's luck in a past game does not predict one's luck in a future game, (j) and that winners in life sometimes are just lucky and losers, unlucky. Examples of the kinds of games we are discussing here are Candy Land® and Chutes and Ladders® (also called Snakes and Ladders in Europe), where players are on a journey of some kind to a destination, with the winner arriving first. The destination is allegedly a land of wonder and enchantment.

Older children and adults generally have moved on in their playing and their cognitive skills. Or have they?

The Game of Wonderland

We suggest that toxic creative leaders appeal to concrete-operational thinking (Piaget, 1950, 1952) in their followers—the level of thinking at which abstract reasoning has not yet come into its own. Only about 50% of people over 12, when presented with a formal-operational task, perform at the level of formal operations (Day, 1981). But that is what they are capable of (maximal performance), not the level at which they think in everyday life (typical performance). If one considers people's willingness to believe much of what they hear presented without evidence, one can only conclude that, in everyday life, people generally do not think formal-operationally (see, e.g., Sternberg, in press). They are a ready target for a game that toxic leaders play, which we will call "Wonderland."[1] In the board games and ideological games, followers reason concretely to follow a prescribed path to a promised future,

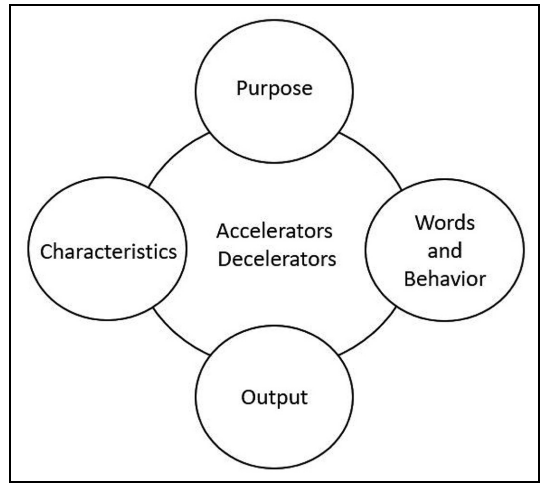

Figure 1. Creative-toxic leadership model (CTLM).

but do not think formal-operationally about all the possible combinations of actions and future outcomes, a kind of thinking characterizing formal-operational information processing (Inhelder & Piaget, 1958). They see only one of the possible action-outcome possibilities—the one prescribed by the toxic leader as presenting a single assured outcome if the followers follow the leader.

In this game, a toxically intelligent politician is seeking as close to absolute power as he (as noted earlier, it is usually a "he," although it occasionally can be a "she") can. How does he attain it? We suggest that the playbook of such politicians is virtually always the same. In particular, toxic creative leaders have (a) special personal characteristics that (b) help them with their purposes, (c) manipulate people with their words and actions, (d) to reach their desired results, (e) given the presence of particular contextual conditions needed for the toxic leaders to gain power and grow it. The Creative-Toxic Leadership Model (CTLM) shows their path to "success." The elements of the model are shown in Figure 1. The idea for the toxic leader is to lead followers to believe that if the toxic leader comes to power or stays in power, the followers can be assured of living in a land of wonder and enchantment, or

of being restored to the great land they once lived in before saboteurs took over.

Our focus in this article is on leaders at a national level. As noted above, the same principles that apply at the national level can be applied at any level of government, and as well in organizations of various kinds within nations. To describe the operations of toxic leaders at other levels as well would take more space than we have for this article, but the principles are applicable at any level, from the local level on upward.

Characteristics of Creatively Toxic Leaders

Beyond what other researchers have suggested as particular characteristics of toxic leaders (Lipman-Blumen, 2006; Sternberg, 2019a, 2019b), these creatively and intelligently toxic leaders have special beliefs about the world and the game of Wonderland. Creatively toxic leaders subjectively perceive the game of Wonderland in a way that is different from how the game is perceived by many others (see, e.g., Lipman-Blumen, 2006; Sternberg, 2019a, 2019b). The creatively and intelligently toxic leader may think:

1. I can gain great, potentially almost unlimited, power.
2. I fully deserve this power and will use it as it is meant to be used.
3. I will gain this power through sheer strength of will, through creative cunning, and through the pathetic weakness and cowardliness of everyone else.
4. The only way to use the power effectively is to focus on the big picture and not get hung up on details, legalities, and niceties, which do not concern me in the least. Those are for morons to attend to.
5. I am the only one who can wield the power properly.
6. The others who want power are pathetic nobodies who only are interested in stealing it from me for their own benefit.
7. These others need to be squashed and I will squash them in creative ways they will never expect or be able to fight back against.
8. In like manner, I will squash anyone who gets in my way, whoever they may be.
9. I can get the power by figuring out what the people who matter for my acquiring and attaining power want.
10. I will make an overwhelming case that I, and only I, can give it to them—that only I can save them.
11. People are total fools, and my job is to take advantage of this fact. They not only are fools; they want to be fooled and they want a strong leader who will tell them what they can and cannot do.
12. Those who disobey will be punished.
13. What people want is to be viscerally and continuously reminded that they are being mocked, victimized, abused, and suckered out by my enemies, who are also their enemies.
14. Once in power, I can and will modify the system to ensure the continuance of my power, indefinitely, creatively defying the existing order.
15. When I can no longer wield power, I will ensure that the system I set up endures, likely by establishing a family dynasty that will continue the work I have started.

To summarize, the creatively and intelligently toxic leader has a plan for acquiring and maintaining power, and the creativity is in adapting that plan to the circumstances they confront, which may change almost on a daily basis. From the standpoint of the creatively and intelligently toxic leader or would-be leader, the game looks very different from the way it looks to others. Wonderland is merely a contrivance on the way to power. It can be depicted publicly in whatever terms will appeal to those who

choose and must accept the next leader. That is, it is a shell, and one can attach to the shell those details that will make the game appealing in particular settings at particular times for particular audiences.

Following decades of unsteady progress toward increased democracy throughout the world (Moghaddam, 2016; Pinker, 2011), recent events in the United States and elsewhere have signaled a turn toward populism (Brubaker, 2017) and away from democracy, at least as it has conventionally been viewed (Levitsky & Ziblatt, 2023). There is no shortage of contemporary examples of political leaders offering Wonderland to their followers. Once the leader is in power, some things inevitably will start to go wrong. Creatively toxic leaders have a playbook that they adapt to the circumstances:

1. I am responsible for everything that is going right, and I do mean, everything.
2. I am responsible for nothing that is going wrong, and I do mean, nothing.
3. My enemies, and yours, are trying to undermine me by quietly and secretly making things go wrong. They are a fifth column, a deep state.
4. Some of them are pretending to be with us, but they are incompetent or, worse, really virulently against us.
5. I will show you how worthless they are of your trust.
6. We can and will make things better by punishing them as they deserve to be punished and by getting them out of our way.
7. We have a sacred trust to make things right again, and no one and nothing must be allowed to get in our way.
8. We must work together to fulfill our destiny, which means you must take responsibility not only for your own actions, but also for monitoring other people's actions and reporting those who are undermining us.
9. You will be rewarded for reporting them, but if you let them destroy our good work, you can expect to go down with them.
10. You will see, even if you are not yet a believer, that I am the solution to all your problems. I am the "anointed" one.

Purposes of Creatively Toxic Leaders

Although creatively toxic leaders pretend to have positive purposes and to be seeking a common good, their real aims can be totally different. The creative part is implementing the game in a way that appeals to a particular audience at a particular time.

1- They want to have more power.
2- They try to "enchant" their followers—to turn them into "True Believers."
3- They want to be the sole or, if not, leading power in the world or at least the region.
4- They do not want to lose the game, no matter what the cost of winning.

To summarize, the toxic leader has a fairly clear set of purposes related to the acquisition and maintenance of power, but they generally need to execute this plan in an intelligent and creative way that takes into account the unique power dynamics and changes in power dynamics of the situations they confront.

Words and Behaviors of Toxic Leaders

The creatively and intelligently toxic leader or would-be leader often says to his followers something like this:

1. **Praise the targeted followers (making them feel special and superior)**
   - You are the inheritors of this great nation (state, city, village, or whatever). It is a unique, wonderful nation. (Hence, we are labeling it "Wonderland.")

- You are special. You are different. And you are better than those who are succeeding in the nation right now. Yes, much better!
- This is *your* nation, and it is only for you. It was created and developed for you.
- The thieves do not deserve this nation. They are interlopers robbing you of your heritage. Their exact identity varies from one instance to another, but almost always they are minority-group members racial, ethnic, religious), foreigners, or others of low status in the society.
- You are good. They are bad. They are immoral and unscrupulous.
- People are either for the good, like us, or for the evil, like them. Do not be fooled into believing there are shades of gray in our battle between good and evil.
- God (or some other higher power) is with you, not with them. God wants me to win so that you can and will win.
- You may be asked to make personal sacrifices to achieve our sacred goal.
- It is an honor to make such a sacrifice, so you and others can be proud of any such sacrifice you make.

2. **Create a feeling of sympathy and unity between the creatively and intelligently toxic leader and the targeted followers/ Self-idealization**
   - This country is being stolen from me too. I feel your pain.
   - I am the only person—the only one—who can save you.
   - I am not some "random" person. I have been chosen—anointed—to save you.
   - I am being joined by a multitude of people of goodwill and good faith, and in joining up with me, you will be joining this multitude of the just and the righteous.
3. **Impose a fear of a secret conspiracy against the followers / Create the feeling among the followers that they have crafty and unprincipled enemies**
   - What is wrong with this country is actually simple, although the enemy wants to make it sound complicated.
   - Some of the enemies are being deceived by their immoral leaders, but it is their responsibility to recognize this deceit, and they are not living up to their responsibility.
   - Indeed, some within our own country are being deceived by the unscrupulous leaders of the opposition, defying all logic, reason, and moral righteousness.
   - Members of this internal opposition, who are betraying their own country, must be treated as enemies too.
   - Whether the opposition admits it or not, they hate you and so feel justified in stealing your sacred land and other resources from you.
   - They have many ways of cheating you. For example, they are changing the rules of the society. (They are metaphorically taking the "cards" that move them forward on the game board and sticking you with the cards that hold you in place or even move you backward).
   - You are not a victim of bad luck, but rather are being tricked and suckered out.
   - There is no compromise. Compromise means losing the battle.
   - These enemies cause all the problems we have. None of these problems are your fault, and they certainly the problems are not my fault.
   - Either join up with me or you are doomed.
   - You are either with me or you are with the thieves.

- If you are with the thieves, you deserve no sympathy and will be treated accordingly.
- In order for me to fix the problem, you must grant me the power to do what needs to be done.
- This will mean not only escorting you to Wonderland, but getting the interlopers out of Wonderland and out of power.
- There may be some ugliness in kicking them out but there is no other way to get back to Wonderland, much as we wish there might be.
- Obey me, or things will go badly for you and for those you love.

4. **Impose a sense of imminent threat**
   - Your nation is in the process of being stolen from you by enemies.
   - They are working with powerful and sinister forces to steal your country from you.
   - They will do whatever it takes to steal the country away from you.
   - This process will continue until all is lost, not just for you, but also for your loved ones and heirs.
   - You must act to stop this rampant cheating and, indeed, theft.
   - Time is running out. You must act now or it will be too late.
   - Trust me. Trust only me.
   - I will take care of everything so long as you put your faith in me.
   - Do not question or second-guess me.
   - I know far more than you do and more than I can reveal to you.
   - Do all this, and I, and only I, can guarantee that you will end up in Wonderland.

In sum, creatively and intelligently toxic leaders need to understand their audience—their followers and potential followers—and how to reach those followers in a way that is compelling, persuasive, but also that leaves the followers feeling like they have little choice but to follow.

The Wonderland playbook is effective. It taps into core psychological dynamics of belonging, status, and intergroup relations about how people can categorize the political world, creating divisions between "us" and "them," making people feel fear about the present and also for the future (Obradović et al., 2020). Relative deprivation, the idea that people can feel left behind or discriminated against when they make comparisons in relation to salient others, also helps explain some features of the Wonderland playbook (Power, Madsen & Morton, 2020; Stouffer et al., 1949). The darkly intelligent and creative would-be authoritarian leaders tap into these basic psychological processes and feelings to utilize and adapt the playbook within their unique cultural and historical context (Sternberg & Wagner, 1994). One effective way to demonstrate their abilities is via their speeches. Populist leaders exaggerate threats about immigrants (Moghaddam, 2023) and load their political rhetoric with emotionally valenced and divisive words (Maher et al., 2022).

Output of Creatively Toxic Leaders

The outputs of having creatively toxic leaders are almost all unfortunate. They include:

1. Creation of conflict within and between countries (or, in other cases, organizations of various kinds within countries)
2. Formation of enemies, both internally and externally
3. Creation of false opposition of "us versus them" among groups
4. Fomenting of war
5. Creation of a false sense of unified purpose when, in fact, that purpose is only for the creative toxic leader to remain in power and increase his power

To summarize, conflict is a tool of the creatively and intelligently toxic leader. These

leaders use conflict to foster the unity of their own followers and to sow anxiety among their enemies.

Accelerators/Decelerators for Toxic Leadership

As time goes on, both before and after a creatively toxic leader gains power, many people begin to change.

They find ways of meeting their needs through obeying and, sometimes, even adoring the creatively toxic leader. What are these needs? Many of them were recognized by Murray (1938), Frankl (1959/2006), Längle (2003), White (1959), Yalom (1980), McClelland (1983), and Maslow (1993), among other needs theorists. Although people have different levels of these needs, all have them to some degree.

Accelerators

Need for Affiliation. People have a need to belong to something greater than themselves—to feel a part of something. The toxic leader provides a broad and increasingly devoted network of people with whom people feel affiliated.

Need for Power. The toxic leader assures people that he (it almost always is a "he") will empower them and restore to them the power they deserve.

Need for Material Things. The toxic leader assures followers that they have had material loss because of their enemies, and he will restore to them what they deserve.

Need for Status. The toxic leader emphasizes how his target audience has lost their status to others—usually minority-group members, foreigners, and other supposedly "undeserving" people—and that he will restore to them the status they merit.

Need for Affection. The disloyal leaders do not love the people, only themselves. In a classic gambit of reaction formation, they pretend to love their followers when, in fact, they love only themselves because they are narcissistic. Followers also gain affection from other followers.

Need for Competence. The toxic leader lauds the competence of his select group and the utter incompetence or, worse, venality of the enemy.

Need for Achievement. The toxic leader purports to show how the "real" people of the country have been blocked from achievement, and how he will enable them to achieve their full potential.

Need for Meaning. Most of all, the toxic leader provides a sense of meaning—that now people can understand how the meaning in their lives has been robbed from them and that he will restore it through faith in him.

Decelerators. Creatively toxic leaders, in summary, figure out people's needs and how to harness those needs to help them reach their goals. The creativity of the toxic leader is in figuring out how to activate as many of these needs as possible in a way that serves the creatively and intelligently toxic leader's purposes. Most of these needs also can serve as decelerators if they are already being met. For example, if people already have affiliations with prosocial groups, have their power needs met, feel that their material needs are being met, feel they have sufficient status, etc., they have no need for a creatively-toxic leader. The creatively-toxic leader, therefore, tries to convince them that even if they thought their needs were being met, they were wrong. He tries to show them how diminished and victimized they ought to feel.

What to Do about Creatively Toxic Leaders

In principle, there are many steps people could take to get rid of creatively toxic leaders. In practice, there are not nearly so many.

Hold Elections

Elections occasionally work. Jair Bolsonaro was voted out of office. But the effective toxic leaders of the present and past, such as Vladimir Putin, Xi Jinping, Victor Orban, Daniel Ortega, Fidel Castro, Nicolás Maduro, and Aleksandr Lukashenko, among others, rig the elections to make their loss virtually an impossibility. The elections are elections in name only. If Jair Bolsonaro is re-elected in the future, it may be much harder to get him out. As is often the case, the stronger the rational arguments for his having lost, the more his followers believe he won. Ideology or worship of toxic leaders' trumps rationality (Rathje et al., 2023). Elections can work: Poland threw out its autocratic government in October 2023. How well the results will stick remains to be seen.

Educate the Electorate

Educating the electorate should work, in principle. In practice, it is difficult. Autocrats usually take over the media and the schools. Before too long, the press becomes a propaganda outlet for the government and the schools teach whatever invented history of the country the autocrat wants them to teach (Psaltis et al., 2017). Oppositional media find it difficult or impossible to work within the country, and members of the press who oppose the government find themselves accused and often convicted of various invented crimes, or subject to manufactured investigations. Citizens become apathetic and often afraid. Engaging with foreigners in any way may endanger the citizens and they may decide that the engagement is not worth the risk. Surveillance systems, such as in China, become *1984*-like. And, there are always enough people lacking critical thinking, willing to sell out, or seeing financial or other advantage to themselves in simply complying. Education, therefore, often proves difficult but is still one of the best ways to create critically engaged democratic citizens who work toward actualized democracies (Moghaddam, 2016; Power, 2018).

Overthrow the Creatively Toxic Government

Revolutions, whether peaceful or violent, have worked. The velvet revolutions of Eastern Europe have had some success, although the autocrats always seem to be lurking in the background, attempting to engineer their eventual return. South Africa overthrew its Apartheid regime. But revolutions in other countries with tighter controls have failed, and the autocracies in some countries, such as Nicaragua and Venezuela, seem very entrenched. Most Mideastern governments are autocratic and revolutions attempting to overthrow them so far have failed. A common feature of attempted revolts against dictatorial regimes is that one dictator may be replaced by another (Moghaddam, 2024; Moghaddam & Hendricks, 2020). During the Arab Spring in Egypt, for instance, revolutionaries ousted the in-power dictator (Mubarak) only for another (Morsi) to take his place (Wagoner et al., 2018). People in many countries are often not socialized into democracy, or educated about it, and the lack of "democratic citizens" results in a difficulty of establishing new democratic norms, even when a dictator is ousted (Moghaddam, 2016).

Pass on Governing to the Next Generation of Family

The passage of governing on to the next generation of family has rarely worked in practice. In North Korea, for example, the hereditary dictatorship has yielded one toxic autocrat after another. In the Middle East, the children of kings and queens often end up being like their parents, or in some cases, worse. The children

of African dictators have proven to be no more enlightened than their parents.

Hope the Government Will Resign

Waiting for a resignation is usually a futile hope, although it can happen. Some dictators have resigned, usually after ensuring that they will not be prosecuted or persecuted (Christensen, 2018). One then must hope that the resignation is for real, rather than their holding power behind the scenes, and that it is permanent.

Hope for Splits in the inner Circle of Power

Toxic leaders are often supported by an inner circle of powerful elites who support them because the elites gain either financially, or in terms of power, status, prestige, by doing so. However, splits in the inner circle offer the potential for the removal of a dictatorship (Moghaddam, 2013, 2024). Yevgeny Prigozhin, the former leader of the Wagner private military company, who led Russia's invasion of Ukraine, saw an opportunity to march on Moscow and attempt to overthrow Putin. Prigozhin was first neutralized, then supposedly exiled to Belarus, and was ultimately killed—almost certainly, murdered–in an airplane explosion. Conflict in the inner circle offers the possibility that one dictator will be removed but also creates the potential for one autocrat to replace another.

Conclusion

The basic idea of this article is that creatively and intelligently toxic leaders—ones who have novel ideas that are personally useful but poisonous to many others—have a more or less common strategy. Their goal, in large part, is the acquisition and maintenance of power at almost any cost. Such leaders can be found at any level, and often the toxic leaders who reach the national level first were toxic at more local levels of governance or administration. Toxic leaders present themselves not as toxic leaders, however, but as populists who will bring their followers to a Wonderland that represents the best of a country's past and a bright direction for its proper future. They present themselves as the only ones who can lead the country down the path. They count on a number of personality needs that people have, as well as the general lack of critical thinking and emotionality with which people confront many political and generally ideological problems. They gleefully appeal to people's worst instincts and attempt to legitimize these instincts by emphasizing to their followers that what they propose to give the followers is what they deserve and have deserved, but what has been taken away from them.

Creatively toxic leaders are often what has been referred to in the leadership literature as pseudo-transformational (see, e.g., Bass, 1999; Bass & Avolio, 1994; Bass & Steidlmeier, 1999; see also Burns, 1978; Conger & Kanungo, 1998; Sternberg et al., 2021). They pretend to be seeking a common good when, in fact, the only good they really care about is their own. They are creatively and practically intelligent (Sternberg et al., 2008) in convincing followers of their good intentions. They become experts at fooling others into believing in their good intentions (Sternberg & Grigorenko, 2003).

Although toxic leaders present themselves as saviors, in fact, they are interested only in their own fortunes, and in particular, the acquisition and maintenance of power and the gains, such as financial rewards, that will come with it. They are utterly unscrupulous and usually narcissistic, Machiavellian, and psychopathic. As with many people who have personality disorders, they are outstanding at persuading people of their good intentions and at sufficiently disguising their bad ones to gain power. Oddly, they do not disguise all their bad intentions because toxic leaders appeal to so many people who welcome the legitimation of their worst instincts. The toxic leaders present the Wonderland game, full well knowing it is a fraud, but finding it, with the contextual details

they add to make it appealing, a viable way of gaining and maintaining power. When things go wrong, as they inevitably do, the toxic creative leaders accept no blame but rather pin all the blame on others.

The idea of taking a shortcut to some imagined Wonderland is intuitively appealing for many people. We have suggested reasons why people support creatively and intelligently toxic leaders who promise the electorate the benefits of Wonderland that they are made to feel they rightfully deserve. Examining contemporary toxic governments, and a survey of global history, easily reveal the shortcomings of those darkly intelligent and darkly creative toxic leaders who force their way to power through manipulation of citizens. They interpret the rules of Wonderland differently from most people.

If there were a good formula for ridding a country of creatively toxic leadership, countries in thrall to dictatorships would follow it. There is no formula that works in every case, and in many cases, no formula seems to work. What the world can hope for is that, over time, education and the horrors of toxic governments will lead people, where they can, to make better choices and then work hard to ensure that these choices or others like them remain in power. The greatest problem in overcoming toxic leadership is that it is dangerous, perhaps fatal, to combat toxic leaders, and once one decides to combat them, there is no turning back. If one is revealed as oppositional, the toxic leader or his minions will seek to crush the opposition, both to rid themselves of the opposition and for the harsh treatment of the opposition to serve as an example to others.

Populism, and the rise of toxic and often dictatorial leaders throughout the world, has been prolonged and is starting to feel like the new normal (Brubaker, 2017). Some children cheat at Candy Land® and some adults take shortcuts in their pursuit of Wonderland. Democracies can slide toward toxic dictatorships (Moghaddam, 2016). There is no inevitable march toward the Enlightenment ideals of logic and reason (Shweder, 1991). Mitigating the trend toward toxic governance is one of the gravest changes facing humanity.

Psychology plays important roles in world-making (Power et al., 2023). One way in which psychologists can contribute to combating toxic governments, and address the slide toward pseudo-populism and dictatorships, lies in understanding the individual and situational factors that lead to the rise of dictators, and the cultural and historical contexts that give particular form and substance to specific toxic leaders. It can be useful, but it is not enough to run laboratory experiments investigating how people react to different kinds of leaders. Real-world opposition to toxic leaders is nothing like what can occur in a laboratory. In a laboratory, one does not risk the fortune and even the lives not only of oneself, but also of family members, friends, and allies (see Power & Velez, 2022).

Psychologists also need to pay greater attention to comprehending, and finding solutions to, the pressing issues of our time—such as increased migration (Botelho et al., 2022) and diversification of nations and increased economic inequality (Power, 2020)—that would-be creatively toxic leaders exaggerate and manipulate to their advantage by making people feel unfairly treated or neglected on their own journey toward their idealized Wonderland.

Another way to defeat creatively toxic leaders is through education. Psychologists have a key role to play in developing critical thinking and engaging more girls in education throughout the world. These strategies would help foster democratic citizenship among young people, increasing the possibility for genuine democratic reform. Unfortunately, toxic leaders often quickly try to take over the educational systems in their countries, knowing that true education, as opposed to indoctrination, can be their worst enemy.

What kinds of predictions might an account of creatively toxic leadership make? Because world events are basically unpredictable, it is difficult to offer firm predictions about particular events. But one at least can make

suggestions, based on the account in this article. The first is that if countries of the world, such as the United States, continue to educate students in the service of traditional academic credentials, the people in the countries with individuals so educated will be susceptible to ending up with creatively and intelligently toxic leaders. The reason is that their education will include substantial amounts of memorization and perhaps abstract analysis, but not include instruction in the wisdom to recognize the application and effects of dark intelligence and creativity. Countries need to pay much more attention both to (a) developing students' critical and creative thinking and (b) developing them in a way so as to encourage wise rather than toxic deployment of intelligence and creativity. Too many people with fancy educations use those educations for malignant ends. The second prediction is that unless societies find better ways of combating toxic creativity, they will suffer. Pseudo-populist leaders are having a field day in the 2020s because the media simply have not figured out how to deal with them. They often report on them as though they are simply another responsible political party, like their non-pseudo-populist opposition. The world saw how poorly that worked during World War II and the dictatorships that formed before that war, but the media seem not to have learned many lessons about how to cover creative pseudo-populists. A third prediction is that for the world to become a better place, it needs to place more emphasis on rational and critical thinking and less on the mere accumulation of knowledge in the schools (Velez & Power, 2020, 2023). A lot of creatively toxic leaders and their followers are "well-educated." But they often fall into traps of informal logic and conspiratorial thinking that render their educations not particularly useful for combating poorly trained thinking processes.

We are convinced that if there is any road to understanding creatively toxic leaders, it is not through conventional creativity tests, whether traditional ones such as the Torrance Tests (Torrance, 1974, 2008) or more modern ones such as the PISA tests (PISA, 2022). These tests are largely decontextualized and have little to nothing to do with the scope and depth of the problems people encounter in everyday life; and they represent emotional and motivational voids compared with the problems that creatively toxic, or for that matter, positively creative leaders deal with every day in their work. Psychometricians often have simplified psychological phenomena to make them easier to measure, but the risk in doing so is that one may lose the phenomenon as it operates in the real world.

There is hope for betterment in this era of toxic leaders. We have seen, historically, the ways in which countries can transition away from toxic leaders and closed-minded populism, and topple dictatorships or other forms of toxic government. Theoretical articulations can help us comprehend the problems with the darkly intelligent and darkly creative leaders and how to solve the problems these leaders create.

Although this essay has focused on creative and intelligent toxicity as they apply in government, it is worth reminding ourselves that intelligent and creative toxicity are to be found in all kinds of leadership—of corporations, of religious groups, of nonprofit organizations, or of anything else. Cult leaders are typically creatively and intelligently toxic, and the world has no lack of those at the moment. Creative and intelligent toxicity poisons the world at many levels in many domains. We must be aware of toxicity, what it is, and most of all, how we can fight back. Otherwise, what was thought to be impossible—even meant to happen never again—becomes not only possible, but actual.

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Note

1. We originally used the name of a popular children's board game but were advised by university legal counsel to change the name of the game because of the possibility of legal entanglement if we were to use a trademarked name for a board game. In each case, the idea is to follow steps to get to a land of wonder and enchantment at the end of the game.

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